

probability inappropriately higher than the objective probability would warrant.”¹ Langer found that choice, task familiarity, competition, and active involvement can all inflate confidence and generate such illusions. For example, Langer observed that people who were permitted to select their own numbers in a hypothetical lottery game were also willing to pay a higher price per ticket than subjects gambling on randomly assigned numbers. Since this initial study, many other researchers have uncovered similar situations where people perceived themselves to possess more control than they did, inferred causal connections where none existed, or displayed surprisingly great certainty in their predictions for the outcomes of chance events.

A relevant analogy can be found in a humorous, hypothetical anecdote: In a small town called Smallville, a man marches to the town square every day at 6 p.m. carrying a checkered flag and a trumpet. When the man reaches an appointed spot, he brandishes the flag and blows a few notes on the trumpet. Then, he returns home to the delight of his family.

A police officer notices the man’s daily display and eventually asks him, “What are you doing?”

The man replies, “Keeping the elephants away.”

“But there aren’t any elephants in Smallville,” the officer replies.

“Well, then, I’m doing a fine job, aren’t I?” At this, the officer rolls his eyes and laughs.

This rather absurd tale illustrates the fallacy inherent in the illusion of control bias.

PRACTICAL APPLICATION

When subject to illusion of control bias, people feel as if they can exert more control over their environment than they actually can. An excellent application of this concept was devised by Andrea Breinholt and Lynnette Dalrymple, two researchers at Westminster College in Salt Lake City, Utah. Their study entitled “The Illusion of Control: What’s Luck Got to Do with It?”² illustrates that people often harbor unfounded illusions of control.

Breinholt and Dalrymple sought to examine subjects’ susceptibility to illusions of control as determined by the intersection of two common impulses: the desire for control and the belief in good luck as a controllable attribute. Two hundred eighty-one undergraduate students participated in the study, and all rated themselves based on a “Desirability of Control Scale” and a “Belief in Luck Scale” immediately prior to the experiment. The subjects then participated in an online, simulated gambling task. Participants were randomly assigned either a high-involvement or a low-involvement